

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 19: Jewish Mobility Reconsidered

August, 15-16, 2022

Online on Zoom

Gleanings towards mapping the circulation of things Jewish (“choses du sacré”): Amsterdam, Livorno, Bordeaux, Surinam etc.

Evelyn Oliel-Grausz, Université Paris 1 Panthéon Sorbonne/IHMC

Introduction

One type of circulation in the early modern Jewish world has been given limited and insufficient attention so far, the circulation of observance related things. The great variety of these things ranges from ordinary things, “choses banales” to use the trivial expression constructed into a historical category by Daniel Roche, food of all kinds mostly to things endowed with a measure of sacrality, such as for instance, ritual objects or *etrogim*. The circulation of *etrogim* maybe a rare example in this area where a handful of studies try to cast some light on a type of trade/demand that was reiterated year after year by numerous communities in their impossible quest for beautiful, affordable and promptly delivered citrons. This historiographical blind spot is all the more conspicuous that the interest in issues of mobility on the one hand, on material culture and foodways on the other hand has increased considerably. The discrepancy between the importance and centrality of these circulations in our understanding of premodern Jewish societies and the scarcity of the literature can, to a certain extent, be ascribed to the scattered sources. Writing the history of these circulations remains a challenge that can be met with an opportunistic round-about method tracking the traces of these exchanges, and trying to turn the gleanings into a map. This endeavor is not merely descriptive, and cannot be reduced to a list “à la Prévert” as it is often on the occasion of specific difficulties legal, commercial or else, that these artefacts make it to the frontstage. The questions raised by these documents pertain to the history of *halakhah*, of intercommunal communication, of trade, albeit the idiosyncratic trade of observance related items, and of material cultures.

The following documents constitute a sampling of the gleanings culled along the way of research in the history of early modern Sephardic *kehillot*.

Document 1 is a letter taken from the correspondence of a Sephardic commission trader in Amsterdam involved in colonial trade between Amsterdam and Surinam in the 1720's and 1730's, Abraham da Costa, and describes in unusual details the

preparation, storage and shipment of kosher items in Amsterdam (Stadsarchief Amsterdam).

Document 2 is a report on the making and the trading of Kosher wine in Bordeaux in mid-eighteenth century, found in the archives of the Intendance of Bordeaux, or the representative of Royal authority in the French provinces (1752, Archives départementales de la Gironde).

Document 3 is a sampling of two letters on the ordering, supplying and shipping of etroguim between Venice and Amsterdam in the 1770's, taken from the copiador de cartas, that is the registers in which a copy of the outbound letters sent by the community Talmud Torah of Amsterdam and its various officials was kept (Stadsarchief Amsterdam).

Document 4 is composed of two letters sent from Tunis to Livorno in the 1720's on, among other things- the issue of preparation and shipment of meat, on the production and sale of sifre torah, extracted from the incoming correspondence of the Livorno Nazione (Archives of the Jewish Community of Livorno).

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Stadsarchief Amsterdam.

The correspondence of a commission trader between Surinam and Amsterdam (1720's).

« Amsterdam, 28 March 1725

Sr Jacob Henriquez de Barrios,

We have received your two esteemed letters dated last December 4, with Captain Jan Blom et Simon Quaboer by which we were informed that you received ours dated 24 July and August 1st past.

We take notice of your disapproval of the rental of warehouses [pacus] for the goods we are shipping out to you, this being in your opinion nothing but a novelty invented by ourselves and Abrabanel, to which we reply that you are wrong since this is the mercantile custom, and that those who do not pay for it, you may be sure of that, will pay while incurring the expense of keeping the goods aboard, or of loading the shipped goods onboard ; and regarding what you say, that it is not necessary to keep the merchandise and supplies that we are shipping in warehouses, you are arguing against your own interest, since if each one of your suppliers of the goods and supplies we are shipping out were to send to have the merchandise they send loaded aboard ships, the price paid to the mariner/boatman and the expenses for each parcel would amount to much more than the cost of renting a warehouse for a month, not to mention the fact that it is impossible to send aboard some type of merchandise and to send aboard some type of staples/goods : as for instance the coal arriving in vessels from the Rhine which are measured in the market in which the said vessel arrives , and from there taken to warehouses since there is no commercial ship bound for Surinam ; the butter

comes from Leyden, on tugboats which are unloaded in the city, the meats, since we are Jewish, are sent to be salted, kosherized, and packed in special warehouses with a Jewish surveyor. The salt is bought in large quantities to gain 25 p/cent in the price whereas when it is bought in retail it costs between 6 ir even 6f pr OHH [*Hogshead*], and so forth for various other goods, into which we shall not linger so as not to expand our already long letter, and be able to serve your interest with zeal and conscience, and the Flemish correspondents you name are doing the contrary of this, since, considering that they do not charge you for the warehouse rental they will set the interest of the money that they put out at 4 to 6 p/cent yearly, and they will overcharge for some staples, which we do not do; We apologize for dwelling at length upon this issue and being so bothersome with this long letter, and in effect you shall let us know in the future if you wish to pay for the cost of the warehouse, which is a short term item, or if you prefer to pay the cost for each staple to the boatman that will take them aboard, which will raise by much the level of expenses, as we have already said.

As for the price of the snakewood [/pao letro]¹, it remains even, for there was no opportunity to sell it successfully, some are desperate that do not want to be in credit with their correspondents will sell it at f. 3.15 pour 100, which we believe it is inappropriate to do, for, since no letterhout having arrived in the last two ships, the price is bound to go up again, and this we do for your benefit, although we are your creditors.

Following your order, we have insured 10 OHH [*Hogshead*] of sugar at f.50 par OHH [*Hogshead*] with a premium at 4 p/cent in the ship Gekroode lam, Captain Jurian Schonevelt, and we have also insured in the said ship 12 OHH [*Hogshead*] upon order of Mr. Abraham da Costa at f.50, and we shall hold on to the letterhout until it reaches 41/2 for f/5 pour 100 cash in profit as you have ordered, and we request again that you desist from sending anymore letterhout.

We will attempt to receive and sell 2 OHH [*Hogshead*] sugar sent Jan Blom on your personal account.

We had a glass cabinet [glaze Kas] made out of letterhout, a press, a mirror, 12 table feet, exactly as you ordered, however for the eight smooth pieces that you have requested, that is four pieces 28 feet long, and 4 pieces 18 feet long, we have never seen or received pieces of Letterhout long enough, and therefore we inferred that it may be a slip of the pen on your part, and hope for a response from you.

¹ Letterhout en néerlandais.

We have collected information about how much it would cost to factor a dozen chairs and an armchair, and we were asked for between f8-16, when providing the Letterhout [added above the line] – may this serve as an indication.

On the 8 of this month we have sent you a letter with captain Vet saying that the ship Conde Carlo Boromeo Cap^o Jacob de Jongh was wrecked on the coast , and since it was impossible for the ship to pursue its journey, all the goods will be transferred to the Maria Theresa Gerret Cocq, as you can see in the annexed lading bill, and the said Cocq will carry as well the letters first sent] on the Jacob de Jongh, as well as and the accounts for the staples and merchandise for Mrs Abigail et Simha de Castro, and in this way the documents sent on the said Jacob de Jongh are cancelled.

With this letter we are including two current accounts, on from your personal account, in which it appears that you owe us f. 8271,19, and a second company account in which you are owed f.170,9, which two amounts we shall appose and credit [added above the line in new accounts, and we hope that, being indebted to us, you will give us some indication about how much you will offer, and remain as always willing to execute your orders.

May God keep you for many years

Your esteemed friends and servants,

With the ship Maria Theresa, Captain Gerrit Cocq .

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Stadsarchief Amsterdam.

The correspondence of a commission trader between Surinam and Amsterdam (1720s).

“Amsterdam a 28 Março 1725

S[enho]r Jacob Henriquez de Barrios

Ressebemos 2 muy estimadas de Vm. De 4 dezembro passado com os Cap^m Jan Blom e Simon Quaboer pelas quays vemos haverem ressebido as nossas de 24 de Julio e 1 de agosto passado.

Vemos apontar Vm. não poder aprovar o aluguer de pacus das fazendas que lhe remeteremos paresendolhe ser novidade inventada por nos outros e Abrabanel, ao que lhe respondemos a Vm. : que esta muy abuzado pois he estilo mercantil, eos que nao ocaregão sigurese Vm. ocargarão em gastos de levar a bordo, ou de sobrecargar nas fazendas que remetem e tocante aoque Vm. dis que as fazendas e provizoems que remetemos não nessesitão ressebelas em Pacus fala Vm. contra seo interesse, por quanto seos vendedores das fazendas e provizoems que remetemos cada qual mandar o que vende a bordo cargara no jeneros q[ue] entregar, o salio que paga ao barqueiro, e gasto de hum despacho p[ar]a cada partida, eomontara m[ui]to mais do que monto oaluguer de hum mez de pacus ademais ser imposivel mandar algum jeneros a bordo : como por exemplo a Cael vem em enbarcasoems do rim, a qual semide (?) no mercado onde chega ditta enbarcação e dahi p[ar]a opacus por nao haver navio a carga p[ar]a Serinaem ; a manteiga vem de Leide em barcos da sirga os quais descaregão dentro da cidade ;

as carnes como somos Judeus se mandão salgar em pacus propio com hum guardeão Judeó a par para casserar salgar e enpacar. O sal compram[o]s p[o]r partida grande por avansar 25 p.cen[to] no presso, porquanto quando se compra por miudo custa de 5 athe f[lorins]. 6 por OHH [Okshoofd], easim muitos jeneros mays pelo conseguinte, que não referim[o]s p[o]r não nos alargar na escritura e asim servimos a vm. A seo beneficio com zello e consiensa, eos correspondentes framengos que vm. aponta uzão bem ao contrario, pois se nao cagar aluguer de pacus caregara interesse a 4 ea 6 p. cen[to] por anno do dinheiro que estão em desembolso, e sobrecaregão en alguns jeneros, oque nos outros não fazemos, pezame havenos alargado tanto neste ponto de tão pouco valor e enfadar a Vm. Com nossa dilatada escritura, easim avizara Vm. Para oadiante sequer pagar o aluguer de pacus que he couza muy tenue ou siquer melhor pagar os gastos de cada jenero ao barqueiro por levalos abordo que montarao muito mais os gastos, como temos ditto em volta.

F°182

Tocante ao presso do pão letro fica enpatado p[o]r não haver ocasião de vendelo com reputação alguns afogados que não que não [sic] querem estar em desenbolso por suas correspondentes e venderao a f3.15 por 100 (?) o que não acham[o]s conviniente fazer, pois não vindo dessa em 2 frettas mais pão letro sertam[en]te bolvera a subir, isto fazemos a beneficio de vm. ahinda que estamos en desenbolso. Em virtude de sua ordem de Vm.. Fizemos siguro de 10 OHH [Oxhoofd] de asucar a f[lorins].50 por OHH[Oxhoofd] o premio a 4 p. c[en]to no navio o Gekroon de lam Cap-o Jurian Schonevelt como tambem siguramos em d° navio 12 OHH por ordem do s[enho]r Ab[raha]m da Costa a f.50 e guardaremos o pão letro athe ficarem de 41/2 a f.5 por 100 liquido rendim[en]to como vm. Nos ordena, e bolvemos a pedir a vm. não nos mande mais pão letro.

Precuraremos resseber e vender 2 OHH [Okshoofd], de asucar que VM. remete com Jan Blom de sua conta particular.

Mandamos fazer de pão letro hum glaze Kas, huma enpresa, hum espelho, 12 pes de meza torneados, tudo como vm.. Nos aponta, porem os 8 pedasos lizos que vm.. Nos manda pedir a saber 4 pedasos de 28 pes de longo e 4 pedasos de 18 pes de longo, jamais vimos nem ressebemos pedasos de pão letro tão longos , e asim considramos sera abuzo de pluma de que espero reposta de vm.

Nos informamos quanto custara de feitio huma duzia de cadeiras e huma de encosto e nos pidirão f.8 a f. 16 – o dando o pão letro [rajout au dessus de la ligne]- que sirva de governo.

Em 8 deste escrevemos a vm. com o Cap^o Vet haver dado a Costa o navio o Conde Carlo Boromeo Cap^o Jacob de Jongh, e por se achar o navio incapas de proseguir seo viagem se transportarão todas as fazendas no navio o Maria Theresa Gerret Cocq como podra vm. Ver pelo incluzo conhesim[en]to e com d^o Cocq vao as cartas de Jacob de Jongh como tambem as contas do custo das provizoems e miudezas que remetemos aSs^{ras} Abigail e Simha de Castro e assim ficados anulados os conhesim[en]tos de d^o Jacob de Jongh.

F^o183

Com esta vão incluzas duas contas correntes huma de sua conta particular de vm. naqual nos fica devendo f.8271.19 e outra de conta de Comp^a na qual lhe fica devendo f.170.9, cuyas duas sommas cargamos e abonamos [These two words added above the line] em contas novas e achando as Vm. ao dever nos dara avizo sendo quanto se nos ofrese ficando como sempre muy pronto as ordems de Vm. A quem Deus guarde muitos annos.

Muy amigos e servidores de Vm.

Com o navio o Maria Theresa Cap^o Gerrit Cocq

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Bordeaux, A.D.G., C 1089, pièce 57-Kosher wine

“For a number of years now, the Jews established in Hamburg and Altona have been trading wine in Bourdeaux, resorting to Christian merchants to buy the stripped grapes (harvest) from the estate owners, and having them processed and prepared by their own workers as well as by Jewish workers from Bordeaux. These wines were never more heavily taxed than those ordinarily made by Christian traders or by Jews. According to their Laws, the Jews cannot drink any wine but that which they name Kasser; for better safety and in order to satisfy the Jewish wine traders from this place, their Christian commission traders in Bordeaux used to obtain a certificate from the previous Rabbi of the Portuguese nation in Bourdeaux stating that the wine they were loading was truly Kasser, and they gave a small fee to the Rabbi for that certificate.

Approximately 9 years ago some Rabbis and scholars from here (Hamburg) started suspecting the righteousness of the Portuguese rabbi and of his certificates, which compelled them to declare a prohibition in all synagogues on any kosher wine from Bordeaux that came only with the Rabbi’s certificate. This order was reiterated and confirmed by our first Rabbi here, named Jonathan Eybeschuz, who came from Metz three years ago.

Due to this prohibition, Jewish wine traders were forced to sell with great financial loss the wine they had brought over from Bordeaux, since the Jews would not buy it. To remedy the situation, two trusted men were sent by the Jewish community here, and they were expressly ordered to be present during the preparation of the

wine from beginning to end, and to make sure that everything would be done in keeping with Jewish Laws. These two men are still in Bordeaux, at the expense of this community; since the certificate from the Rabbi in Bordeaux has become neither necessary nor in use, it seems the need to pay the fee is moot. It can be checked in the books of the commission traders that since those days it was neither requested nor given. It is possible that the Jews of London or Amsterdam, who are not subject to the prohibitions of our Rabbi here, have continued to receive certificates from the Bordeaux rabbi and to pay the fee.

Such an example should not be used as the law regarding the parties, since the request for this certificate was always contingent and voluntary.

Yet, for the past six years, the Portuguese Rabbi in Bordeaux has claimed from all Jews without making any distinctions, a tax on every barrel of kosher wine, with a similar amount whether a certificate was obtained or not. Upon our refusal to pay, he took his complaints to the Sir Intendant, who gave little credit to his claims. It is of common knowledge that in a kingdom the Sovereign is the only one who can levy new taxes.

And besides, Jewish laws do not allow any Jewish community to levy taxes upon foreign Jews.

However, the Portuguese rabbi did not desist from his claims, and in order to obtain the collection of a tax that he wanted to impose, he obtained the assent of the Elders and the syndics of the Portuguese Nation of Bordeaux, and they tried to pass off this tax as a legitimate collection to be used for the sustenance of the Nation's poor.

German Jews have neither association nor harmony with the Portuguese, and on the contrary, they constitute two different sects.

In 1751 the Jewish wine merchants from this town ordered from their Christian commissioners in Bordeaux the required quantity of wine to be processed by their employees. These employees were disrupted in their work by a proclamation posted by the Portuguese Rabbi and the Elders in all the synagogues, by which they forbade every worker, whether from their nation or a foreigner, to make Kasser wine unless the 4# duty per barrel was paid.

This prohibition, entailing sensitive sanctions for the Jews such as the denial of burial rites, or the ban from the Jewish baths for their wives, and other similar sanctions proved so intimidating to the workforce that they abandoned their task.

Upon the complaints brought to the Sir Intendant by the Christian commissioners, the latter first halted the execution of that prohibition and ordered the Rabbi, the

Elders, and the syndics, to provide their arguments. Since the said commissioners, knowing very little about Jewish Laws, did not express their opposition and did not reply to the arguments brought forth by the Elders, the Sir Intendant was led to consent to their arguments as legitimate, and produced on February 123, 1752, an ordonnance by which he decides against the commissioners and condemns the latter to pay 4# to the Elders and syndics for each barrel they had loaded or would load.”

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Taxes communautaires et surveillance halakhique de la fabrication, entre Hambourg et Bordeaux

Bordeaux, A.D.G., C 1089, pièce 57

"Il y a nombre d'années que les Juifs établis a Hambourg et à Altona font un trafic de vins a Bourdeaux, faisant acheter la dépouille des vignes des propriétaires par des marchands Chrétiens, ils les font travailler et préparer à leurs manières tant par leurs propres ouvriers que par les ouvriers Juifs de Bordeaux. Ces vins n'ont jamais payé plus d'impots que ceux que font négociant chrétien ou juif paye ordinairement.

Selon leurs Loix les Juifs ne doivent point boire d'autre vin que celui qu'ils nomment Kasser ; pour plus de seureté, et pour satisfaire les marchands de vin Juifs d'icy, leurs commissionnaires chrétiens a Bordeaux ont pris autrefois un certificat du précédent Rabin de la Nation Portugaise à Bourdeaux pour constater que les vins qu'ils chargeoint étoient véritablement Kasser, et ont donné une petite gratification au Rabin pour ce certificat.

Il y a environ 9 ans que les premiers Rabins et Savans Juifs d'icy ont eu quelques soupçons de la droiture du Rabin Portugais de Bordeaux et de ses certificats ce qui les obligea de faire défendre dans toutes les synagogues de recevoir le vin de Kasser de Bordeaux muni du seul certificat du Rabin. Ce mandement a été renouvelé et confirmé par le premier Rabin d'icy nommé Jonathan Eybeschuz qui est venu de Metz et où il est depuis trois ans.

Par cette défense les marchands de vins juifs ont été contraints de vendre à grande perte aux Chrétiens leurs vins qu'ils avoient fait venir de Bordeaux, les Juifs

n'en voulant point acheter. Pour y remédier on a envoyé à Bordeaux de la part de la Communauté Juive d'icy deux hommes affidés auxquels il a été expressement ordonné d'être présents à la préparation des vins depuis le commencement jusqu'à la fin, et d'avoir soin que tout fût observé selon les Loix Judaïques. Ces deux hommes demeurent toujours à Bordeaux aux dépens de la Communauté ; le certificat du Rabin de Bordeaux n'étant plus nécessaire ni d'usage, on ne se croit plus obligé à la gratification. on peut vérifier par les livres des commissionnaires que depuis ce tems là, elle n'a été ni demandée ni donnée. Il se pourroit que les Juifs de Londres et d'Amsterdam qui ne sont point soumis aux défenses de notre Rabin d'icy ont continué à prendre les certificats du Rabin de Bordeaux et à luy payer la gratification.

Cet exemple ne doit point servir de Loy aux parties, la demande du certificat ayant toujours été indifférente et arbitraire.

Cependant depuis six ans le Rabin Portugais de Bordeaux a prétendu indistinctement de tout juif un impôt sur chaque tonneau de vin Kasser, soit qu'il prit un certificat ou qu'il n'en prit point en fixant même la somme. Sur le refus que nous avons fait de payer, il en a porté ses plaintes à M. l'Intendant qui a parfaitement connu le peu de fondement de ses prétentions. tout le monde sait que dans un Royaume il n'est permis qu'au Souverain de mettre des impôts nouveaux.

Et d'ailleurs les Loix Judaïques ne permettent à aucune communauté Juive de mettre des impôts sur les Juifs étrangers.

Malgré cela le Rabin Portugais ne s'est point désisté de ses prétentions, et pour obtenir la perception d'un droit qu'il vouloit imposer, il a attiré dans son party les Anciens et les Syndics de la nation Portugaise à Bordeaux, et ont voulu faire passer cet impôt comme un droit du et qui devoit être employé à la nourriture des pauvres de leur Nation.

Les Juifs Allemands n'ont aucune connexion ni communion avec les Portugais, ils forment au contraire deux sectes différentes.

En 1751 les marchands de vins Juifs d'icy ordonnèrent à leurs commissionnaires chrétiens à Bordeaux la quantité de vin dont ils avoient besoin et de la délivrer à leurs gens pour la travailler. Ceux-ci furent troublés dans leur travail par un mandement que le Rabin Portugais et les Anciens avoient fait publier dans toutes les synagogues par lequel ils défendoient à tous ouvriers soit de leur nation soit étranger de faire du vin Kasser qu'ils ne leur eussent payées le droit de 4# par tonneau.

Cette défense sous des peines sensibles aux Juifs comme d'être privés de sepulture, leurs femmes bannies des bains Judaïques et autres peines semblables a tellement intimidé les ouvriers qu'ils ont abandonné leur travail.

Sur les plaintes que les commissionnaires chrétiens apportèrent a M. l'Intendant il fit d'abord suspendre l'exécution de ce mandement et donna ordre au Rabin, aux anciens et aux syndics de produire leurs raisons. Les commissionnaires peu informés des Loix Judaïques ne s'étant point opposés et n'ayant point répondu aux raisons des anciens, M. l'Intendant fut porté à recevoir ces raisons comme fondées, et de faire le 12 février 1752 une ordonnance par laquelle il donne défaut contre les commissionnaires et les condamne à payer aux anciens et Sindics 4# par tonneau de vin Kasser qu'ils avoient chargé ou qu'ils chargeroient."

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Two letters from Amsterdam to Venice on etrogim

Stadsarchief Amsterdam, PA334, Copiador de cartas.

« Most Illustrious Gentlemen Parnassim of the General University of the Jews in Venice,

Amsterdam, 30 September 1773,

Gentlemen, We received in its time the Gentlemen's estimated letter dated 3 and 10 September with a notice regarding the shipping of a small box with 40 citrons, which we received, and we express our gratitude for the good zeal employed in the service of this *Kahal Kados*; notwithstanding the good trust in our friendship we find it necessary to bring to your knowledge that when this box was opened with much caution we found that the said citrons were almost all of poor quality and none was perfect; it is true that all over they did not come out favorably this year, but we have been informed that a box arrived [here] in which most were better and beautiful so that we suspect that these [people], despite the export prohibition in Corfu that Your Highnesses have made us aware of, by way of some maneuver, obtained directly the best ones, or else that the person that Your Highnesses entrusted with our errand did not devote it the required attention, and we beg you to investigate [the matter], so that next year, May Gd benevolently allow us to reach it, we can avoid that an individual be given preference over an entire *kehila*, asking you therefore to provide us in that time with an identical quantity of citrons, which will please us considerably; the amount for those received is p. 39 which yields f.86.14 Banco at the rate of 88^{7/8} so f.86.14 per p., which our Gabay drew, was accepted and will be collected in its time; and since we sold on September 16/m of advance for the affair in favor of your University, our Gabay drew today in favor of Your very Illustrious Highnesses a letter of 436.16.6 p. Banco at usance to the bearer Guayta e Comp[anh]a, the value of these amounts to f. 960.14 Banco

at the exchange of (? Pound Flemish) 88 per P., which we entrust to your good care, and at the same time we congratulate you for the beginning of the New year, in which we pray Gd to grant you prosperity and added years, and that you may celebrate the upcoming holidays with contentment in company of your respective families, and May Gd keep you well for numerous years;
Affectionate Servants of your very Illustrious Gentlemen,
The parnassim of the Jewish Nation,
Signed, Moseh Telles da Costa, Joseph de David Mendes da Costa”

Stadsarchief Amsterdam, PA334, Copiador de cartas.

“Amsterdam 11 8-bro 1778,

Illustrious Gentlemen, We received in their time the much esteemed [lettres] from Your very Illustrious Gentlemen dated 28 August, 2, 11, & 18 September; we acknowledge everything you said had happened this year with the *Etroguim* and specifically with your shipment to us of 40 p. on behalf of this K.K; we cannot refrain from expressing our well founded / legitimate complaints, and greatly surprised by what you claim explains the bad quality of the *etroguim* this year, as we have seen the boxes that various individuals have received from your city; even when many were *pessulim*, the remainder was beautiful in shape as well as in color, and some of the most perfect that came for a number of years, whereas ours were ugly and misshapen, and none was perfect and sent by mail by courier just as if they had been pouches of diamonds, and this resulted in the fact that we paid here f.156.18 for transportation when individuals received it by “conduta” (coach) and some by express [mail] to Augusta[Augsburg], and its total cost was 5f per piece, all arrived on time and only a few days after ours; considering the above, we cannot comprehend what moved your Illustrious Highnesses to ship ours by courier, causing us to pay such an excessive shopping cost, and since it is the latest harvest, there is no reason that justifies it, and pondering with reason the vague excuses formulated, it seems the quill of your accountant should erase it; besides the cost you mentioned of f.156.18 with expenses of fl53.9 amounting to

330 pounds paid in the Flemish Post, and we protest and demand you reimburse us, and we were so bothered by these events that we discussed protesting the payment sent by your accountant of the said 1534.0 banco, but ultimately in order not to tarnish ou, we paid the letter, so that the 40 cost 317.12 f cash, and they are ugly and bad, and from all of this we conclude that you were misled regarding the poor quality, and as for the extraordinary way chosen for the expedition, it seems the

person who was entrusted with it lacked good sense, because the individuals did not experience such disappointment, and they arrived here in due time, it is painfully clear that the money from the chest of the poor has been wasted, and for that we request the restitution of the £330 that you charged us, because we paid the shipping here; if about this commission we entrusted you with, or the person whom you gave instructions to has specific reasons to disdain us, we think that Your Illustrious Highnesses should give us some explanations in your reply in order to take other measures for next year....[The end of the letter, deals with financial matters connected with a loan from the Hague community, has been left out.]

Yours Most illustrious Highness Affectionate servants, Parnassim of the Jewish Portuguese Nation,

Signed H. Abram Abendana de Britto, Aron Spinosa Cattela Jessurun”

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Evelyne Oliel-Grausz, Université Paris 1 Panthéon Sorbonne/IHMC

Two letters from Amsterdam to Venice on etrogim.

Stadsarchief Amsterdam, PA334, Copiador de cartas, 1773-1784

1/ SAA, PA334, Copiador de cartas, 1773-1784

"Muy Illustres Senhores Parnassim da universidade Geral dos Hebreos de Veneza, Amsterd[a]m 30 Setembro 1773

Senhores, Em seos tempos resebemos as muy estimadas de Vms muyto Illustres de 3 e 10 setembro com avizo da expedição de huma caixinha com 40 sidroems cuyos resebemos elhes damos as graças pelo bom zelo tenem para fazer servico a este *Kahal Kados* não obstante na boa confiança de sua amizade achamos indispensavel

o por em seo conhesimento que havendo aberto ditta caixa com muyto pezar achamos que dittos cidroems quaize todos forão podres e nenhum perfeito, bem he verdade que universalmente não sahirão favoravel este anno, porem nos consta chegou huma caixa os quais se acharão por mayor sem averia e bellos de modo que sospeitamos que estes não obstante a prohibição da extracsão em Corfu como Vossas Senhorias nos apontão, por via de alguma intriga os tiverão directamente os milhores, ou bem a pessoa que Vossas Senhorias encargarão desta nossa incumbencia não lhe applicou a devida atenção, que suplicamos tenham a bondade de inquerir, e que para o proximo anno que Deus nos chegue com bem prevenhão que hum particular não tinha preferencia sobre huma *kehila* inteira, pedindolhes em consequencia de remeternos para esse tempo igual quantidade de cidroems no que nos farão particular gosto, o custo das resebidos sao p.39 qua ao cambio de 88^{7/8} sao f.86.14 Bco que sacou Osenhor Gabay a nosso cargo que fica aceita e a seo tempo sera recolhida- e havendose vendido em 1-º setembro as 6/ m avanço da

negociação a cargo dessa universidade, sacou ojem nosso Gabay da sedaca a cargo de VS m-to Illl-es letra de p. 436.16.6 de Bco a uzo a ordem de Guayta e Comp-a valor de dittos que ao cambio de 88 por P. monta f. 960.14 Bco que recomendamos a seo bom cuydado e ao mesmo tempo lhes felecitamos na entrada deste anno novo no qual rogamos a D-s de concederlhes properidades e augm-tos celebrando as proximas festas com todo contento em comp-a de suas respectivas familias e G-de p-r dilatados annos

De VS muyto Illustres Muy affectos servidores,

Os parnassim da nacao Judaica portuguesa

Firmados, Moseh Telles da Costa, Joseph de David Mendes da Costa »

2/ SAA, PA334, Copiador de cartas 1773-1784

"Muy Illustres SS-res Parnassim da universidade geral dos Hebreos de Veneza, Amsterdam 11 (?) 8bro 1778,

Illustres SS-res, Em seos tempos resebemos as muy estimadas de VS muito Illustres de 28 agosto, 2, 11, & 18 Settembro, reconhesemos todo o que nos dizem tem susedido este anno com os Etroguim e sobre o particular do envio nos fizeraõ de 40 p. conta deste K.K. não podemos deixar de remostarlhes nossas bemfundadas queixas, admirandonos muito do que nos avizão em ordem o motivo dama qualidade de *etroguim* este anno, quando temos visto as caixas que diversos particulares reseberão dessa, soposto que ouverão muitos *pessulim*, os demais forão bellos tanto da forma como da cor, e alguns tão perfeitos quanto em annos vierão, os nossos forão feos & disfigurados & nenhum perfeito & expedidos plo coreo na mala igualmente como se fossem bizallos de diamantes de que resultou que pagamos nesta por porte f.156.18 quando os particulares os reseberão pela conduta & alguns por expreso the Augustos este ultimo não sahirão custando em tudo a f. 5 a pessa, todos chegarão a tempo & poucos dias depois dos nossos”, avista do referido não podemos apersebernos o que motivo a VS m-to Illustres de expedir os nossos plo coreo fazendonos pagar hum porte tão exesivo, pois oserem do ultimo corte como dizem nao he rezaõ equivalente, e considranos as escuzas abstractas a boa rezaõ, e como tal a pluma de seu caxeiro devia suprimilas , independante dos f.156.18 nos avizao custarao nessa com os gastos f.153.9 Banco comprehendido livras 330# pagos na posta de Flandes cuya partida reclamamos e pretendemos senos bonefique e tao agravados do sucedido estavamos em deliberação de bolver a protesto a saca seo caixero dos sobre dittos f.153.9 Bco, com todo por nao deslustrarlhes pagamos ditta

letra, do modo sahem custando os 40 f.317.12 de caixa, & isso feos e maos de todo o qual devemos concluir VS m-to Illustres forao enganados em ordem ama qual-d & em quanto a extra ordinaria via da expedicao, parece faltoù conhesimento a pessoa a quem o encargarao, pois os particulares nao sufrirao estes desapontos e chegarao a tempo a esta, he bem sensivel se aya malbaratado (wasted) o dinheiro da caixa dos pobres, e como tal requerimos a restituicao das £ 330 que nos debitarao pois que nesta pagam- o porte, se esta nossa comicao lhes he de encargo, ou a pessoa a quem deixarao a direcsao tenham rezoems particulares para nos desviar, estimaremos VS m-to Illustres se expliquem em reposta para tomar outras medidas plo anno proximo.....[The end of the letter, deals with financial matters connected with a loan from the Hague community]

De V.M. m[ui]tos Illustres Muy Affectos Servidores, Os Parnassim da nação judaica Portugueza

H. Abram Abendana de Britto, Aron Spinosa Cattela Jessurun”

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Livorno, ACEL, Filza de cartas, 1727-8. Two letters from Tunis to Livorno, 1727

1/ ACEL, Filza de cartas 1715-1723, n°118, 27 tebet 5487

Most Illustrious Dayanim and Masares of the Holy Community of Livorno Tunis,
27 Tevet 5487 [20 January 1727]

May this [letter] find you in the perfect health desired, and it was that a woman from Algiers named Melexa presented herself in front of our Magistrate, wife of Yexiya Coen, informing us that her said husband had sold and delivered a *sefer Torah* to be paid one piece and a quarter every month, and Sir Moseh de Semuel Coen from your city having accepted the task of collecting this sum, and it was deposited and put in the house of the late Sr Beniamin Sacutto, and after this order was given him he went away to travel the world, and currently it is not known where he is, and also she says that she was informed that her said husband sent from Tripoli another *sefer torah* so that it be sold; she produced before us such complaints with much crying as she was giving us information about the great ordeals she experienced with her family in foreign parts without receiving any help from anyone, that we felt compassion, and knowing your benevolence, and having been informed that the said Sr Coen is a Gd fearing man, we were brought to write the present letter informing you of the whole case, so that you may see in which way this poor woman may be helped in recovering her husband's due interests, may you receive from Gd for such pious work the rightful reward...

2/ ACEL, Filza de cartas 1715-1723, n°248, October 8, 1728.

« Most Excellent Sirs Daianim and Massari of the K.K. of Livorno
Tunes, 8 October 1728,

After greeting V.M. and wishing that you may enjoy perfect health, the present serves to inform you that Gracia Calvo de Castro being currently here, when she was in your city she had married her daughter with her nephew Abraham Lopes Siera, and he gave her *qedusim*, and after coming to this city, for all the attempts and manners she tried to convince him to come here to marry, promising him numerous commodities, he never wanted to do so, misleading her with words, and lastly he married with whom he wanted, and during these she resorted to us so that we write the present letter to your VM so that at least he will send her Get that she may be free to hope a better fortune, this being a heavy charge on the conscience that the poor woman remains here, bound, and this being a great work of charity, and your VM will pursue what is to be done in reason and by way of Justice, and we shall not expand [on this matter], May Gd grant you a reward for that which you will do.

This also serves to inform you that we have received news that some have written from your [city] asking if the *alxale* and the salted tongues that are customarily sent from here if when the animals are killed, to remove the fat, *nefixa* is done, to which we shall say that here it is not general, some take that precaution and others do not, and this how our *daianim* have always been used to do here, we do not stand watch in the meathall to know those that are with *nefixa* and those that are not, may this serve to inform you and guide you, in case someone wants to send some of the said *alxale* and tongues. As always, we are expecting an answer to what was written [and sent] in the previous ships, and when it occurs we shall inform you, remaining eager to your orders, may Gd protect you for numerous years.

Joseph Mendes Ossuna

Abraham de Isaque Lumbroso

Moseh de Abraham Franco

» משה דרמון

[another signature in Hebrew]

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Livorno, ACEL, Filza de cartas, 1727-8. Two letters from Tunis to Livorno, 1727

1/ ACEL, Filza de cartas 1715-1723, n°118, 27 tebet 5487

Muy Ill[ustre]s Ss[enho]res Dayanim e Masares do K[ahal] K[ados]
de Liorne

Tunes, a 27 tebet 5487

Esta ache a Vmds com a saude perfeita q[ue] se desegião e sendo que se presento em este noso Magistrado uma argelina chamada Melexa mulher de Yexiya Coen noteficandonos em como d[itt]o seu marido bendeu e mesa um sefer Tora apagar uma peza e um quarto cada mes avendo degiado a incumbensa e proccura de d[itt]a cobransa a ese S[enho]r Moseh de Semuel Coen q[ue] esta aposentado e mesa em casa de seu tio bm S[enho]r Benjamin Sacutto e que depois de averle degiado d[itt]o ordem se foi p. os mundos aoqual presentem[en]te não se save donde esta, como assi mesmio dis que neim notocias de q[ue] ditto seu marido mando de Tripole ad-o Sr Coen otro Sefer Tora p[ar]a q. selo bendese; forao tantas as esclamasois quel fes diante de nos com grandes choros com fazernos informar as grandes mizerias q[ue] pasa em comp[anh]a de sua familia em terra forasteira seim ter socoro de nenhum que de compadesidos ereconhosendo a benegnidade de Vmd eavernos informado de que d[itt]o Sr Coen ser pessoa temeroso de D[eu]s nos oblige a fazer a pres[en]te noteficandoles todo o sobre d[itt]o p[ara] que begiao o modo i q. d-a pobre mulher segia socorida dos intereses d. d[itt]o seu marido que de tal obra pia saraõ de D[eu]s terão o pago que é q[uan]to p agora se nos offreze dezir nos recomandandonos em todos Vmd mui de coração a queim D[eu]s G[ar]de m[uito]s a[n]nos

Daianim e masares da nasao portugueza

Beniamin da Carra

Isaaque franco

2/ ACEL, Filza de cartas 1715-1723, n°248, October 8, 1728.

« Exc[ellentissi]mos Ss[enho]res Daianim e Masares do K[ahal] K[ados]
de Liorne

Tunes , 8 8-bre 1728

Depois de salutar a Vmd, e que os ache com a saude perfeita que se desejaõ sirve
noticiarles como achandose aqui Gracia Calvo de Castro aqual quando estava em
essa avia desposado sua filha com seu sobrinho Abraham Lopes Siera, avendolé
dado *gedusim* e depois de aver vindo a esta, p.[or] mais q[ue] ques fazer modos e
maneras p[ar]a persuadilo de que viesse a esta à casarse com bastantes combeniencias
que le prometia, nunca quis conseguilo entretendoa com palavras e p[er] Ultimo se
caso e mesa com quem le pareceu a qual em ò inter que ò supo recoreu a nosotros
que figiesemos a pres[en]te a Vmd p[ar]a que ao menos de que le mande seu Get
quedando libre a esperar sua fortuna sendo que e um grande cargo de consensia que
a pobre quede aqui atada que p[or] ser que é bastante obra de caredade e Vmd farao
solecitar o que de rezao e Giustizia nao alargamos e do que obrareim de D[eo]s terao
o pago.

Sirve tambem avisar a Vmd como tubemos noticiais em come ubo queim escrebeu
de esa preguntando se ò alxale e linguas saladas que soim mandar de aqui aesa se
quando matao os animaís p[ar]a begitar se faseim nefixa aò que diremos que aqui
nao e general ai queim fas escurpulos eai queim nao o fas q[ue] assi sempre se
acostumo em esta e nostros Daianim nao estamos p. guardias em a carneseria p[ar]a
saver as que sao com nefixa e as q. nao sao, que les serva de avizo e governo.
Esperando reposta como nos emos de conter p. ò ouvir para satisfasao de Vmd ; p.
si acaso algum quigier mandar de d[itt]as alxale e linguas. Como tambeim esperamos
reposta do escritoles em as embarcaçois pasadas q[ue] asi importa conforme les
avisemos quedando mui pr[on]tos a suas ord[e]m a queim D[eu]s G[ar]de M[uito]s
A-s

Joseph Mendes Ossuna

Abraham de Isaque Lumbroso

Moseh de Abraham Franco

» משה דרמון

[another signature in Hebrew]